

Understanding English irregularities

THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE HAS BEEN SHAPED BY MANY LANGUAGES.

English has its foundations in Latin and Greek and continues to evolve as foreign words are adopted. With so many influences, it is understandable that English has so many spelling irregularities.

Latin influences

Latin is more than 2,000 years old and originated in the Roman Empire. English has adopted Latin at different times in history. In the years of the Roman Empire (27 BCE–476 CE), contact with Rome introduced new vocabulary. During the Middle Ages (fifth–fifteenth centuries CE), Latin was the language of the Church, which exerted an enormous influence on language—in fact, the first printed books were religious texts. In subsequent centuries, people invented words for new things by combining existing Latin words.

cominitiare

This Latin word means “to begin” and is the origin of the English word *commence*.

superbus

This Latin word means “superior” and is the origin of the English word *superb*.

verbatim

This Latin word means “word for word” and is still used today.

Greek influences

Ancient Greek literature and myths have greatly influenced the English language. Most Greek terms in English were created by combining Greek roots to describe things named in modern times, such as *dinosaur*. For this reason, Greek words are usually technical words used in medicine and science.

skeleton

This Greek word means “dried up” and is the same as the English word *skeleton*.

pharmakon

This Greek word refers to a place that dispenses medicine and is the origin of the English word *pharmacy*.

deinos and saurus

In Greek, the word *deinos* means “terrible” and *saurus* means “lizard.” When combined, they form the origin of the English word *dinosaur*.

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REAL WORLD

The Domesday Book

The Domesday Book was written in Latin and compiled in 1085–1086 CE. It is Britain’s earliest public record, and was drawn up on the orders of King William I to describe the resources of late eleventh-century England. Latin was the language used for government documents and by the Church, and continued to be used for important documents up to Victorian times.

